



FROM ZERO TO PRO - MODULE 01

Kitchen Foundations: Safety, Sanitation & Setup

A safe, clean, organized kitchen is the platform every other skill stands on.

Weeks 1-2 - watch, study, cook, reflect

By the end of this module

- 1 Practice the core rules of food safety: the temperature danger zone, cross-contamination, and FIFO storage.
- 2 Set up an efficient, sanitary workstation and clean as you go.
- 3 Identify the essential tools and how to maintain them.
- 4 Read a recipe like a pro: scaling, mise en place, and timing.

LESSON 1.1

Food Safety and the Temperature Danger Zone

Objective: Keep food out of the temperature range where bacteria multiply fastest.

Key points

- Danger zone: 40-140 deg F (4-60 deg C); limit total time there to under 2 hours.
- An instant-read thermometer is the only reliable doneness test - buy one.
- Thaw in the fridge, in cold water, or in the microwave - never on the counter.
- Cool hot leftovers quickly (shallow containers) before refrigerating.

Technique

- 1 Chill**
Keep your fridge at or below 40 deg F; verify with a fridge thermometer.
- 2 Separate**
Store raw meat on the bottom shelf so it cannot drip onto other food.
- 3 Cook**
Use a thermometer to hit safe internal temps (see Reference Library).
- 4 Cool**
Get leftovers below 40 deg F within a couple hours; divide into shallow pans.

LESSON 1.2

Sanitation and Cross-Contamination

Objective: Stop harmful bacteria from moving between raw foods, surfaces, and ready-to-eat foods.

Key points

- Use separate boards: one for raw protein, one for produce and ready-to-eat foods.
- Wash hands 20 seconds with soap after handling raw meat, eggs, or trash.
- Clean removes visible soil; sanitizing kills microbes - do both on surfaces.
- Be aware of the top allergens when cooking for others (e.g., nuts, shellfish, dairy).

Watch out for

- Slicing salad on the same board you just cut raw chicken on.
- Wiping hands on a towel instead of washing them.
- Tasting with a spoon and double-dipping it back into the pot.

LESSON 1.3

Setting Up Your Station and the Mise en Place Mindset

Objective: Organize a workspace so cooking is calm execution, not a scramble.

Key points

- Prep everything before you turn on a burner; reading mid-cook costs you control.
- Keep a 'garbage bowl' on the counter to keep your board clear.
- Set a damp towel under your cutting board so it cannot slip.
- Clean as you go - idle minutes are for washing, wiping, and resetting.

Watch out for

- Starting to cook with half the ingredients still in the fridge.
- Letting scraps and dirty tools pile up until the station is unusable.
- Hunting for a tool while food burns.

LESSON 1.4

Reading, Scaling, and Timing a Recipe

Objective: Read a recipe like a plan, not a story, and run it on a timeline.

Key points

- Read the whole recipe twice before starting; note the prep hidden inside the steps.
- Work by weight (grams) when you can - it scales cleanly and travels between recipes.
- Build a backward timeline from serving time so components finish together.
- Salt and cook times do not scale perfectly; taste and check, do not just multiply.

Watch out for

- Discovering 'marinate overnight' an hour before dinner.
- Doubling a recipe in a pan too small to brown - everything steams.
- Following volumes for baking instead of weighing.

Practice & homework

1

Deep-clean and reorganize your kitchen using FIFO; photograph before/after.

2

Print the Temperature & Doneness guide and post it inside a cabinet door.

3

Write your own one-page kitchen safety checklist and follow it for one week.

Watch & learn (free)



Internet Shaquille (efficiency & fundamentals)

<https://www.youtube.com/@internetshaquille>



Adam Ragusea (practical home technique)

<https://www.youtube.com/@aragusea>



USDA FSIS - Safe Minimum Internal Temperature Chart

<https://www.fsis.usda.gov/food-safety/safe-food-handling-and-preparation/food-safety-basics/safe-temperature-chart>



FoodSafety.gov - Safe Minimum Internal Temperatures

<https://www.foodsafety.gov/food-safety-charts/safe-minimum-internal-temperatures>



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Next up - Module 02: Knife Skills & Mise en Place

FROM ZERO TO PRO - THE SELF-TAUGHT CHEF PROGRAM